



I LOVE DOUBLES. EVEN WHEN I WAS A SINGLES PLAYER, I HAD A PASSION FOR PLAYING DOUBLES. I LOVE SINGLES AS WELL. BUT THERE'S SOMETHING ABOUT DOUBLES THAT I LIKE – GAYATRI GOPI CHAND

Treesa: I was surprised when Gayatri played doubles. I think when she played juniors, she played both awesomely. She played doubles in juniors as well. But she was very good at singles. She's much better than me, for sure. If I play singles, she will beat me below ten! After lockdown, she shifted to doubles, and the coaches decided that we would play doubles together. They felt that the combination would be very good. That's how it went.

Gayatri, was it ever difficult to deal with the expectations that come with being Pullela Gopi Chand's daughter?

Gayatri: It's something that I can't avoid. At the same time, he's never put that pressure on me. He is very chill. He always tells me to just play and enjoy myself. He tells me, 'Whatever happens, I'm happy with you.' There's never been any pressure from his side.

I've noticed you have a tattoo on your right arm. What's that about, and was that something he was chill with?

Treesa: Finally, someone asked her about it!

Gayatri: I just liked the design, so I got it. It's the yin-yang symbol. Although Treesa and I get along really well, it's not about her. It's something that makes sense to me. It's about balance, but I mostly got it because of the design. Dad was okay with it.

Dad liked it. I had asked him before getting it. I talked to him about getting a dad-daughter sort of tattoo, but he told me, 'Why do you want to get something on your body?' And ultimately, Dad is in my heart!

Two Indian pairs are very strong right now. Aparna Popat told us that the strength in women's doubles is India's biggest strength

Best mates: "What I like about Treesa is that she is very energetic most of the time. Unless, of course, she is sleeping," says Gayatri. SANDEEP SAXENA

in women's team events now. What's it like to have another really strong Indian pair who is on your side at the Asia Team Championships but who you also have to compete with?

Treesa: We practise with Ashwini didi and Tanisha (Crasto). The experience we can gain by practising with Ashwini didi is a lot. Even at this age, she is playing really well. That's the inspiration we get from her. She has extensive experience playing against various countries and in different conditions, which she shares with us. It is a pleasure for us to learn from her because not everyone gets this opportunity.

Gayatri: People say there is a different pressure when playing someone from the same country. But it's the same. There's always pressure. I've never gone into a match without pressure.

There's a bit of competition between the two of you about who gets to go to the Olympics.

(Ashwini and Tanisha Crasto are the higher-ranked Indian pair at World No. 20 compared to Gayatri and Treesa, who are World No. 23.) The Games are just a few months away. Is it something you guys are thinking about?

Treesa: We don't specifically think about the Olympics. Right now, we are playing in Europe. There's the German Open, the French Open, and then the All-England. There's a lot of tournaments coming up. We know that if we play well, we could make it to the Olympics.

Gayatri: At this moment, we want to do well in the tournaments that are coming up. If (Olympic qualification) it happens, we will be really happy. But if it doesn't happen, it's not the end of the world. We are just looking forward to the tournaments we have right now. Just playing against different players. Sometimes, the pressure is